

SUMMER MOVIES

SPACE INVADERS

Fireworks flame as aliens attack Earth in \$65 Million 'Independence Day'

BY DAN YAKIR

SPECIAL TO THE CHRONICLE

New York

It's a steamy summer day, but thousands of New Yorkers pay no attention to the heat. They are facing the crisis of a lifetime: Aliens have invaded and are about to turn their town into rubble. People are throwing suitcases and packages out of windows. An intersection in Soho is teeming with bumper-to-bumper traffic, full of panicky locals trying to get out. In all this mayhem, though, one cyclist seems to have something else on his mind as he pedals against traffic.

Location Shooting

"Cut," yells director Roland Emmerich, wiping his brow. He's just finished a day of shooting on his \$65 million science-fiction extravaganza, "Independence Day." The title is also the date of the film's alien invasion. The movie itself is scheduled to open on July 3. The thousands of fleeing New Yorkers are movie extras; the cyclist is played by Jeff Goldblum.

Calm and composed, the German-born Emmerich explains that the cyclist is a cable company employee who discovers something wrong with the signal and is first to detect the aliens.



Jeff Goldblum on the New York set of 'Independence Day'

To those watching the shoot, there is no sign of aliens. They'll be added later by special-effects people; the shot of the sky will be substituted by a blue screen on which 15-mile-wide spaceships will be superimposed.

When New York, Los Angeles and Washington, D.C., explode in a dramatic six-minute segment

Emmerich will use miniature spaceships and computer technology to composite people and models together.

Even without supernatural sights, the shoot attracts hordes of New Yorkers, fascinated by the mayhem and confusion being filmed in their midst. Even for savvy locals who are used to both

to miss out on anything. He uses three cameras facing different directions for maximum exposure.

Goldblum appears a bit dazed, having arrived from the West Coast just a few hours before shooting. But his grasp on the movie and his character is firm: "This scene is something, isn't it?" he says. "All this chaos with thousands of panicky people trying to leave town — and I'm the only one who knows that there's this countdown and that they're really going to strike at a particular time."

According to Goldblum, the movie assumes that the Roswell incident of the 1950s — when a UFO allegedly crash-landed in Arizona — is true. "We go into Area 51 in Roswell and see the ship that's still there and the preserved corpses of the aliens," he says.

Innocent Thrills

The thrills of "Independence Day" are fairly innocent. "From the very beginning I said, 'No blood,'" Emmerich says. "This is a summer-event film that means to be fun; we were very careful not to brutalize an audience that's already seen too many nasty movies."

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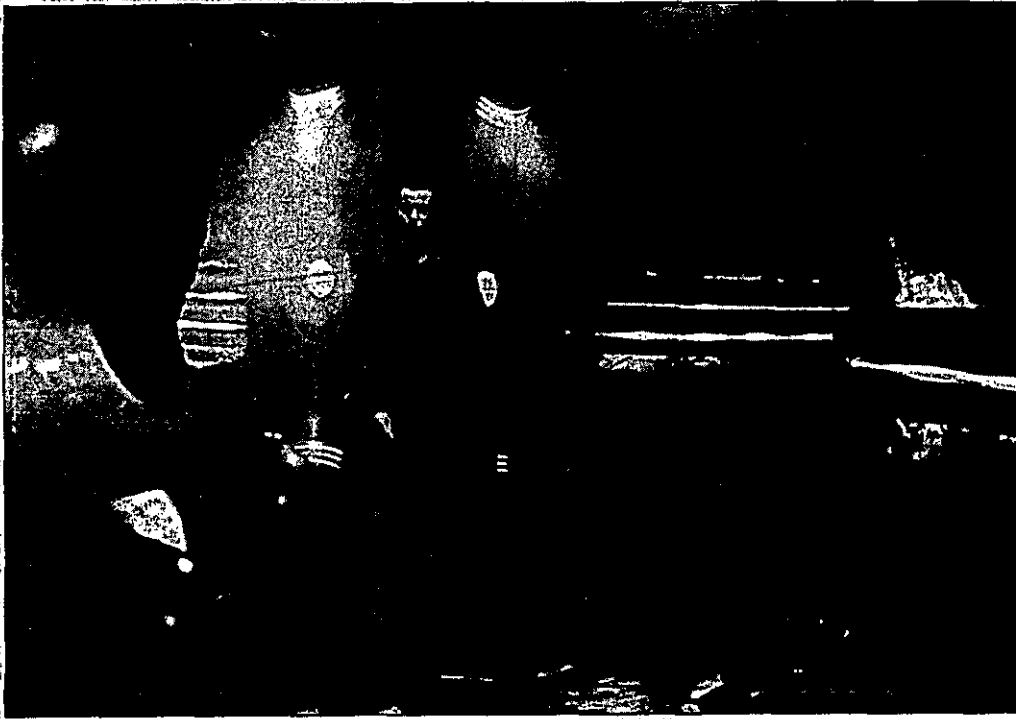
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SUMMER MOVIES



Charlie Sheen in the sci-fi psychological thriller 'The Arrival'

FRIGHT FEST

'Tis the season for Hollywood to scare audiences silly with aliens and natural disasters

BY RUTH STEIN

CHRONICLE STAFF WRITER

Just when you thought it was safe to go outside and enjoy the warm weather, here comes Hollywood with a warning: It's dangerous out there.

Of all the formulas for summer movies, scaring audiences out of their seats remains the most durable. Sharks, dinosaurs and King Kong are some of the creatures to have roamed the big screen in summers past, shredding nerves along with various limbs. Every natural or unnatural disaster known to man has been vividly portrayed as well.

This time, it's killer tornadoes shaking us up in a darkened movie house. "Twister," which opened this weekend, getting a jump on summer, is a \$70 million saga about monstrous cyclones, written by Michael Crichton, who terrified everybody a few summers back with "Jurassic Park." His new movie follows storm chasers whose job it is to stay ahead of a deadly twister. Naturally, they don't always get there in time, so there are scenes of victims being ripped out of storm cellars and flattened under houses.

And coming soon: Space aliens invade earth intent on destroying it in "Independence Day" and "The Arrival."

As the ancient Greeks knew, it's cathartic to watch the other guy get it. "You're sitting safely in your cozy movie seat and what's scary on the screen is one stage removed," said Francis Higney, retired San Francisco psychiatrist and inveterate filmgoer. "You can vicariously pull your

leg away from the shark's jaw in time."

"Twister" is a perfect example of what he calls "the anticipatory fear," that draws audiences to these movies. "You are there, and you are seeing the twister coming right after you just like the big fin in 'Jaws.' It's the kind of

You're sitting safely in your cozy movie seat and what's scary on the screen is one stage removed; you can vicariously pull your leg away from the shark's jaw in time.

thing 10-year-old boys like to see to show their bravado."

Since summer is such a benign season, so much mayhem may appear misplaced. But this is when young people are, out of school, and Hollywood counts on them to bolster the box office.

Big-name movie stars aren't a necessary lure to get kids into theaters. Like "Jurassic Park" and last year's "Congo," the new summer thrillers star B-list actors. Helen Hunt and Bill Paxton are the tornado chasers in "Twister." Jeff Goldblum stars in "Independence Day." Scary summer movies are becoming his specialty; Goldblum also was in "Jurassic Park."

"Independence Day" doesn't open until July 3, but the

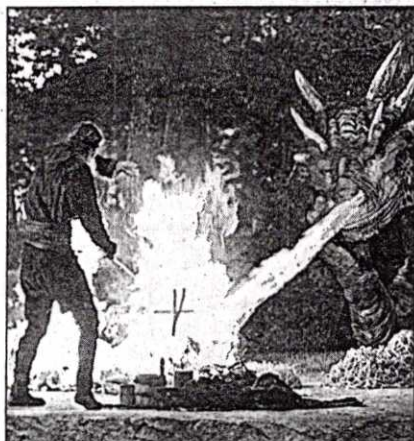
trailer already is showing everywhere. The 15-mile-wide articulated spaceships in which the alien troops arrive are pretty impressive, as are the shots of the White House, Capitol and Empire State Building being blown up. For all its special effects, however, the \$60 million movie looks like a throwback to the 1950s Buck Rogers Saturday serials.

A sense of impending doom before the aliens arrive is created by hovering objects that cast shadows over the screen. There's the obligatory scene in which the experts grimly forecast the date and hour of the alien landing. As in almost all movies about evil aliens, the military is called in to protect the population. In the trailer, Will Smith, as a crack Marine fighter pilot, is shown practically jumping out of his seat while waiting for his orders. "I'm really anxious to get up there and whip E.T.'s ass," he says, referring to the lovable creature in the 1982 movie.

In the early movies about an invasion from outer space, the alien beings were always villains. But in Steven Spielberg's "E.T. The Extra-Terrestrial" and "Close Encounters of the Third Kind," they were depicted as benevolent and sweet. "That became the cliché. In a sense, we're reinventing it again," said Dean Devlin, who wrote and produced "Independence Day."

But the real models for the movie, according to Devlin, were the disaster movies of the 1970s such as "Earthquake" and "The Towering Inferno." "Since those movies, everybody has a home video camera; therefore, every

SCARY MOVIES (Page 37)



Dennis Quaid and friend in 'Dragonheart'

directed by Harold Ramis, is an oddball fantasy comedy. Overwrought husband Doug (Michael Keaton) has himself cloned and throws his wife (Andie MacDowell) for several loops.

Good for curiosity and fun, "The Adventures of Pinocchio" (July 26) stars Jonathan Taylor Thomas ("Home Improvement") as the puppet in this live-action version (with help from Jim Henson's creatures). Martin Landau plays Gepetto.

"Jock" (August 7), starring Robin Williams as a 10-year-old boy with a medical condition that causes his body to age

In the middle of all the diversity in this year's summer movies for kids, look for plenty of silliness

four times the normal rate, was directed by Francis Ford Coppola and filmed in the Bay Area.

"Kingpin" (June 26) may roll past very young kids with its PG-13 rating. The comedy from the makers of "Dumb & Dumber" stars Woody Harrelson as a down-on-his-luck, small-town bowling champ who meets an innocent Amish farmer (Randy Quaid) who is secretly a bowling addict. Bill Murray co-stars.

Murray gets top billing in "Larger Than Life" (July 19), as a guy who inherits an 8,000-pound elephant named Vera who can land him some cash if he can get her across the country in five days. It's not easy.

In "House Arrest" (July 26), a teenager and his 10-year-old sister learn their parents (Jamie Lee Curtis and Kevin Pollack) are about to split up, so they decide to lock them in the basement. Other kids in the neighborhood love the idea and lock up their parents, too.

"First Kid" (due in August) stars Sinbad as a Secret Service agent in charge of the president's son (Brock Pierce). Going through adolescence at the White House is far from a snap.

"Alaska" (August 14) is a wilderness adventure drama aimed at young audiences. It's about a teenage brother and sister who brave the wilds to rescue their pilot dad after his plane crashes. They also befriend a polar bear cub. Fraser C. Heston directed the film, which features his dad, Charlton.

"The Stupids" (August 30) is about America's most stupid family, led by Tom Arnold. It's based on the popular children's books by Henry Allard and James Marshall. The kids are named Bug and Petunia and the family dog is Kitty.

Some offbeat films that might hit with teenagers are "Cold Comfort Farm" (May 24), a send-up of Jane Austen genre novels starring Stella Gibbons as a young heroine sent to a Sussex farm, and "Joe's Apartment" (July 26), about a young man (Jerry O'Connell) who moves from Iowa to New York and finds he has 50,000 six-legged roommates in the form of cockroaches. It's based on an MTV short and features live-action and animation.

Literate kids might relish the adaptation of Truman Capote's growing-up story, "The Grass Harp" (screenplay by the late Stirling Silliphant), due August 23.

SCARY MOVIES

From Page 35

type of natural and unnatural disaster has been captured on videotape, so people have actually seen those things," Devlin said. "To truly create the 'event' feeling of the old disaster movies, we had to create a worldwide disaster in a way that not only has never been seen, but would be impossible to ever see. So we chose a worldwide alien invasion."

Aliens Up to No Good

Aliens also are up to no good in "The Arrival," which opens May 31. A radio astronomer, played by Charlie Sheen, is obsessed with listening for signs of life in space. Late one night he hears a clear radio transmission from space. Writer-director David Twohy calls his movie "the flip side" of a NASA project to terraform Mars to make it more like Earth so humans could live there.

In "The Arrival," "the aliens are already terraforming Earth to make it more inhabitable for to their needs and less inhabitable to our needs," said Twohy, a science-fiction buff who wrote "Alien" and "Waterworld."

"Independence Day" and "The Arrival" are the first of a rash of movies about extraterrestrials attempting to destroy civilization. Tim Burton is directing "Mars Attack!" — a major-cast (Jack Nicholson, Annette Bening, Pierce Brosnan) invasion epic due out at Christmas. It's based on a set of trading cards that came out in 1962 and had parents complaining because of the gruesome pictures of aliens annihilating humans and animals. Other hostile-alien-takeover

movies in production: "Starship Troopers," "DNA" and "Men in Black."

These movies come at a time of heightened interest in aliens. More people claim to have seen unidentified flying objects. Late-night talk radio is filled with chatter about these phenomena, and TV shows such as "The X-Files" play on that interest.

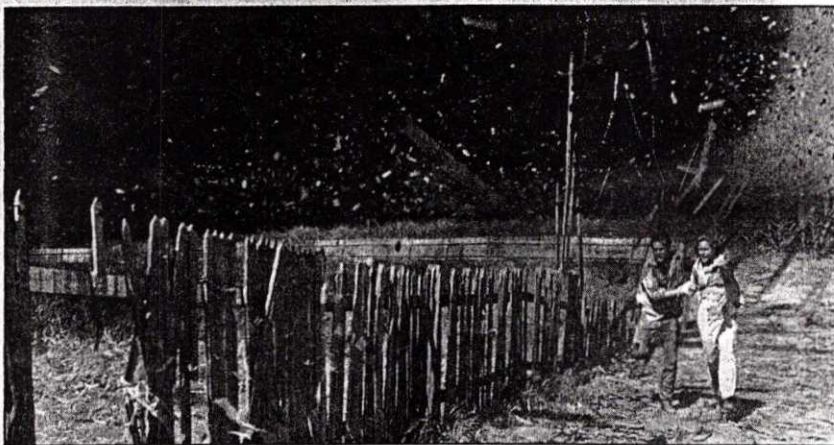
The new films also may have been inspired by the recent discoveries of Jupiter-size planets by San Francisco State astronomer Geoffrey Marcy and his colleague, Paul Butler. "Suddenly we have proof of other worlds on which the biochemistry of life can flourish," Marcy said. "These worlds may harbor our cosmic cousins evolved from the same womb of the natural laws that gave birth to life on Earth."

The negative portrayal of aliens on the screen bothers Alex Filippenko, an astronomy professor at UC Berkeley. "These movies incorporate our own aggressive natures. We could easily destroy ourselves. We don't need aliens to do it," he said.

Technologically Advanced

His theory is that in order to travel to earth, visitors from another planet would have to be "really technologically advanced" and therefore probably pretty civilized. "They will simply be curious about us and not want to take us over."

That scenario wouldn't make much of a scary summer movie. But there are always natural disasters for film makers to fall back on. Production is about to start on not one but two movies about volcanic eruptions.



Bill Paxton and Helen Hunt, as Bill and Jo Harding, flee from a tornado in 'Twister'

HIT PREDICTIONS

From Page 34

acter shadings of that earlier film. Ellen Barkin co-stars as a sports announcer, and the dynamics of the three stars could make for a winner.

Meg Ryan Cast Against Type

■ "Courage Under Fire" (August 2): Denzel Washington plays an Army colonel investigated for his part in a Persian Gulf War incident. Meg Ryan, cast against adorable type, is a helicopter pilot.

Prognosis: Encouraged by positive preview screenings, 20th Century-Fox reportedly bumped this up from fall to summer. Washington's a reliable if sometimes stiff screen presence, and Ryan gets a chance to prove she can do more than twinkle and glow. If you liked "A Few Good Men," this may be your dish.

■ "The Spitfire Grill" (August): Prison parolee Allison Elliot tries making a fresh start in a tiny Maine village. Crusty cafe owner Ellen Burstyn gives her a job and Marcia Gay Harden befriends her while some locals shun her.

Prognosis: This is the movie that Castle Rock Entertainment paid a whopping \$10 million for at the Sundance Film Festival, prompting industry cynics to question the investment. Sweet, simple and uplifting, it also won the Audience Award at Sundance and could pull in the "Driving Miss Daisy"/"Fried Green Tomatoes" crowd.

■ "Tin Cup" (August 9): Kevin Costner is a washed-up golfer who finds a partner/muse in comely Rene Russo. Ron Shelton, who gave Costner his finest moment, "Bull Durham," wrote and directed.

Prognosis: Costner's been dragged through the mud the last few years, what with "Wyatt Earp," "Waterworld" and an overpublicized divorce. This may be his return to form.

Proceed With Caution

■ "Striptease" (May 24): Had enough of Demi Moore yet? Ms. Superstar was paid \$12.5 million to bump and grind as a mom who loses her daughter in a custody battle and goes to work at a strip club to make ends meet.

Prognosis: Not good. Bad publicity, resentment toward Moore (whose previous three films flopped) and the rank odor lingering from the similar "Showgirls" could easily sink this venture.